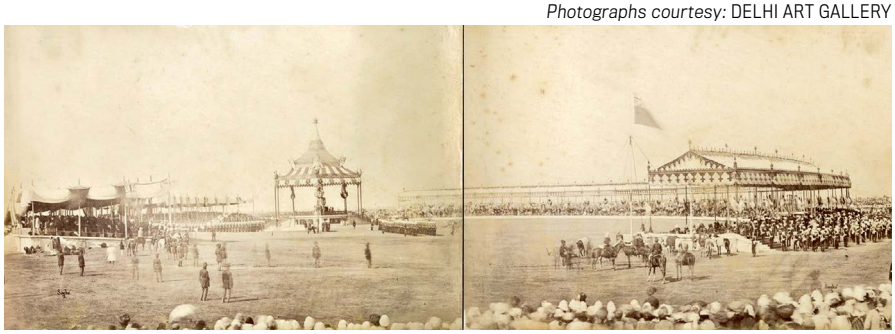
Photographs courtesy: DELHI ART GALLERY





A CITY'S PAST
(top, from left) An 1830 painting showing a cupola atop Qutub Minar that was added by Major Robert Smith in 1829 and later removed in 1849; Imperial Durbar (1903) by an unidentified artist; Proclamation Day Jan. 1, 1877, clicked by John Edward Saché; (left) Durbar armchairs with footstools, 1911

conducting these elaborate Durbars, it was all part of this line of thinking.

Liddle writes: "The Company continued to use the name of the emperor on its coinage till the 1830s, and British officials accepted titles from him. The Persian seal of the governor general, which he used in his correspondence with Indian princes and personages, designated him *fidwi-e-khas*, or 'trusted servant' of the emperor. High officials of the Company, such as the commander-in-chief of the army, participated in the elaborate court ceremonial of the Mughals, appearing in the emperor's durbar, or court, and paying homage."

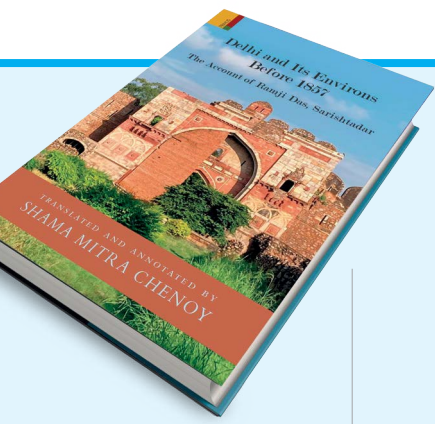
According to Ashish Anand, CEO and MD at DAG, some of the most interesting pieces in the exhibition are photographs by Felice Beato, the most successful commercial war photographer of the 19th century. He came to India in 1858 and documented the aftermath of the 1857 battles. Anand says: "Although Beato arrived in India when the revolt was almost over, he photographed in a manner that attempted to show the immediacy of the events, providing evidence of the violence that had occurred. He travelled throughout north India with the British troops and photographed the cities that had witnessed the Mutiny, especially Delhi, Kanpur and Lucknow."

One of the eye-catching exhibits at *Delhi Durbar* is a 9 x 12 inches photograph by Beato. It captures the Red Fort's Naqqar Khana, and a nearby tree under which a large number of Europeans (the caption to the photograph claims as many as 119) were killed by sepoys in June 1857. Another British artist, Mortimer Menpes, attended the 1903 durbar and painted many scenes from the event, including likenesses of the many Indian royals, landlords and other wealthy gentlemen who attended.

"The starting point of this exhibition goes back a decade or so, when we began to proactively build our archives from what was a pure artist archives to one containing vintage photographs, books and documents relating to Indian history over the past two centuries. This was based on the underlying understanding that history and art and culture are deeply intertwined," says Anand about the process behind the creation of *Delhi Durbar*.

If you're curious about how the intersection of colonialism and Mughal courts played out in practice, or what the public response to these durbars was like, head down to DAG and see for yourself. ■

Aditya Mani Jha



DELHI AND ITS ENVIRONS BEFORE 1857
The Account of Ramji Das, Sarishtadar
Translated and annotated by Shama Mitra Chenoy
PRIMUS BOOKS
₹1,295; 224 pages

ance and tenacity to track and follow Ramji Das on his trail and record fascinating facts as on the parganas: "In the earlier times 'Suba was a type' of name of a possession classified as several sarkars. A sarkar was the name of a collection of many *mihals* [wards], for example, zila and the pargana meant a ward and a pargana had a few *tappas*. *Tappa* was a small part of a pargana and consequently the only person connected to the *Tehsil* by reason of contract with regards to renting or the only person whose rent was *mu'afi* [his quit rent was excused] was known as *tappa*."

Shama Mitra Chenoy writes of her painstaking interest in the upgradation of the facts related to physical forts, palaces, mosques, bridges, temples, dams, waterbodies and changed topographies by comparing past texts to the present reality: "Reading their works one by one seems to give a sense of *déjà vu* but actually what one goes through is *jamais vu*."

She corrects some misnomers over time: 'Murat Devi, now known as Mansa Devi', 'the temple of Harin Das [now called Hari Das]'. There is loss in the recording of facts like 'Nothing exists of *Qila-e Marzghan* or *Kilokheri* or *Khizrabad*. Dargah Nizamuddin Aulia is situated in the site of *Qila-e Marzghan* while Humayun's Tomb was later constructed in the region of Kilokheri in central Delhi towards the South'.

Now that such historical nuggets have been fished out from Persian, Arabic and Urdu texts, it is for the authorities to publicise this information in the signage and publications of the sites that still remain. ■

Aman Nath